

Arashk Afshar

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Public Economics, Political Economy, Microeconomic Theory; Game Theory, Behavioral Economics

EDUCATION

Rutgers University, New Brunswick, NJ

Ph.D., Economics (expected March 2027)

M.A., Economics, 2023

Advisor and Dissertation Committee Chair: Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau

University of Washington Tacoma, Tacoma, WA

B.A., Business Administration (Finance), *Summa Cum Laude*, 2019

B.S., Mathematics, *Magna Cum Laude*, 2019

Green River College, Auburn, WA

A.A., Business, *Highest Honors*, 2016

JOB MARKET PAPER

Saving as a Luxury Good: Why Progressive Taxation Cannot Guarantee Falling Inequality

When the rich save a systematically larger share of their wealth, the distribution pulls apart on its own, and no conventional tax instrument inherits the classical guarantee that progressivity compresses it: commodity taxes can reverse their own equalization, and income taxes fail for every luxury preference. The wealth tax alone reaches accumulated wealth at its source, yet it too carries no guarantee—what governs the long-run trajectory is not the tax rate but the elasticity of retention, how post-tax wealth scales with pre-tax wealth at the top. Because every enacted or proposed wealth tax is asymptotically proportional there, it leaves this elasticity essentially undisturbed, and the debate has been conducted over the wrong parameter.

WORKING PAPERS

The Myth of the Informed Voter

This paper develops a model of political campaigns in which advertising manipulates voters not by informing them but by directing their attention to issues chosen by candidates, who are selected by elites. Under unlimited campaign funding, the equilibrium concentrates voter attention on a narrow set of issues and favors more extreme candidates. Restricting funding reverses this: the equilibrium shifts toward a more moderate candidate and a better-informed electorate, offering an equilibrium rationale for campaign-finance limits without abandoning voter rationality.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Saving as Instrument and Status: Progressive Taxation in a Dynamic Economy

Extends the static analysis to a life-cycle economy, where saving carries additional force as both an instrument and a marker of status; preliminary work suggests this strengthens, rather than weakens, the case for marginal progressivity.

TEACHING

Instructor of record, Department of Economics, Rutgers University

- **Econ 440: Economics of Income Inequality and Discrimination** — Spring 2025, Spring 2026. Designed the course and syllabus from a dormant catalog listing.

- **Econ 402: Labor Economics** — Summer 2024, Summer 2025. Designed the syllabus and introduced a research-project-based assessment.
- **Econ 320: Intermediate Microeconomic Analysis** — Summer 2023, Fall 2025. Taught from a fully calculus-based treatment, including regular-semester sections of seventy-five.
- **College Writing 101**, Department of English — Fall 2024.

TEACHING AWARD

Sidney I. Simon Award, 2024 — for outstanding teaching by a graduate student, Department of Economics, Rutgers University.

OTHER ACADEMIC EXPERIENCE

- Teaching Assistant, Rutgers University, 2021–2024
- Research Assistant, University of Washington Tacoma, 2018–2019
- Academic Tutor, University of Washington Tacoma, 2016–2020
- Academic Tutor, Green River College, 2014–2016

HONORS AND FELLOWSHIPS

- Nominated, President’s Medal, University of Washington Tacoma
- Interdisciplinary Award, for outstanding treatment of mathematics within other areas of study, University of Washington Tacoma
- *Pi Mu Epsilon* (mathematics), *Beta Gamma Sigma* (business), and *Phi Theta Kappa* honor societies
- Multiple merit scholarships, University of Washington Tacoma and Green River College (Milgard, Next Step, Dean’s, Floyd H. Miller Foundation, Shannon & Associates, Undergraduate Merit)

SOFTWARE

Python, R, Stata, MATLAB, $\LaTeX$

COMMUNITY SERVICE

- Volunteer Tax Preparer, United Way of King County
- Volunteer Tutor, University of Washington Tacoma and Green River College

LANGUAGES

English (fluent); Farsi (native)

REFERENCES

Oriol Carbonell-Nicolau (Advisor and Committee Chair)

Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · carbonell-nicolau@rutgers.edu

Richard P. McLean

Distinguished Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · rpmclean@economics.rutgers.edu

Andrew Mackenzie

Assistant Professor of Economics, Rutgers University · andrew.k.mackenzie@rutgers.edu